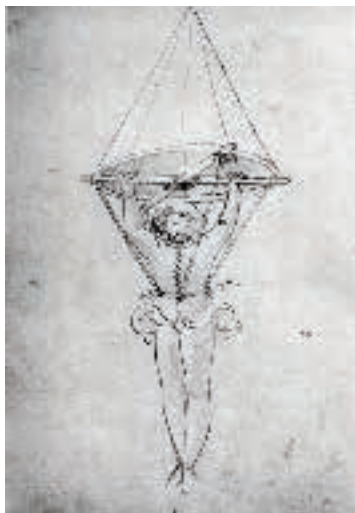


against' and the word chute meaning 'fall'. That's what a parachute does, right? The word was first used in 1785, the technology, much earlier. One of the earliest depictions of a parachute comes from the word, Codex Atlanticus of the most popular multi-talented person in history – Leonardo da Vinci. That was around the year 1485.

Since then, the list of scientists and countries working on the safety apparatus and tests done on it to arrive at the modern version is quite long. Desperate times call for desperate measures, a phrase that certainly rings true for the parachute, much of whose development happened during World War I and II.

Speaking of wars, one of the biggest uses of parachutes has been to drop soldiers from the sky. That's not all. They're also deployed to drop basic amenities such as food and clothes in flood-stricken areas in times of need. Parachutes find application in fun and entertainment as well as in expeditions ranging from mountain jumps to shooting rovers to our planetary neighbour, Mars. While an energy drink company claims that its product gives you wings, it's the parachute that does it for real!



Particle Accelerators

Back in the day particle accelerators were called atom smashers. This misnomer relates to a class of accelerators known today as colliders (ala LHC), but the moniker certainly gives you a clue about what these machines are supposed to do. A particle accelerator uses energy to accelerate charged particles in defined paths. Sounds fancy, but you'd be surprised to know your old TV was a particle accelerator also. The cathode ray tube used in TVs of yesteryear is an electrostatic accelerator. The other type of accelerator is the oscillating field accelerator and it uses radio frequency electromagnetic fields rather than static electric fields to accelerate particles. The large hadron collider is an oscillating field accelerator.

It's estimated that there are 26,000 accelerators worldwide and only a